

Title

Telehealth-delivered support module for family caregivers navigating dementia institutionalization: protocol for a randomized mixed-methods implementation study

Abstract

Admission of a loved one to residential dementia care precipitates significant emotional distress in family caregivers, with high rates of depression and anxiety. Few interventions specifically address the adjustment to institutionalization. This protocol describes a mixed-methods trial of the Residential Care Transition Module (RCTM), a 12-month telehealth program combining six structured sessions with therapist-guided ad hoc consultations. A total of 240 primary caregivers will be randomly assigned 1:1 to the intervention or attention control arm. The RCTM delivers psychoeducation, problem-solving strategies, and emotional support tailored to residential placement challenges. Data collection includes validated scales for depression (PHQ-9), care-related stress, and mastery at baseline, 3, 6, and 12 months. Qualitative interviews with 30 purposively selected caregivers will explore intervention mechanisms and implementation factors. Fidelity is monitored through session recordings and therapist documentation. Mixed-methods analysis will integrate quantitative outcomes with thematic qualitative findings.